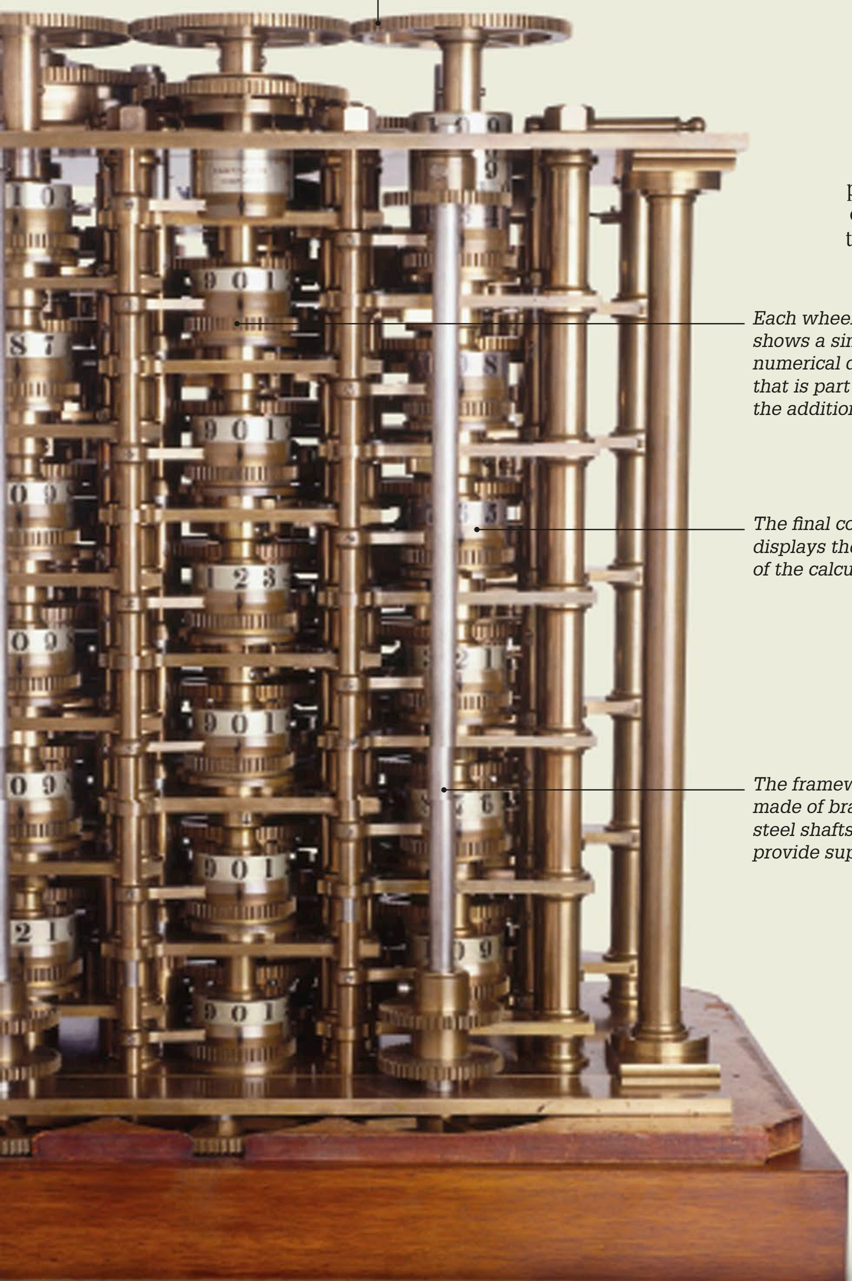
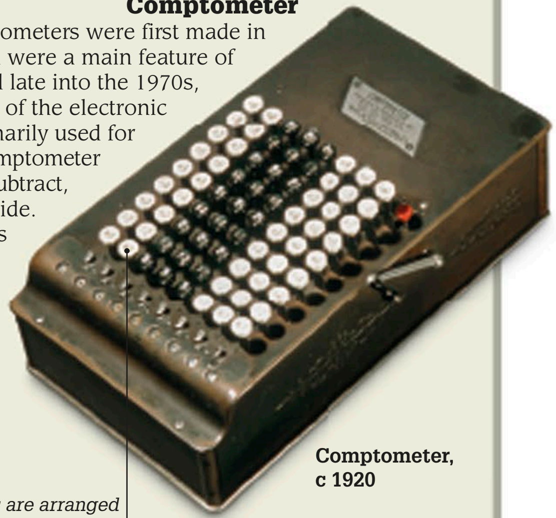


Comptometer

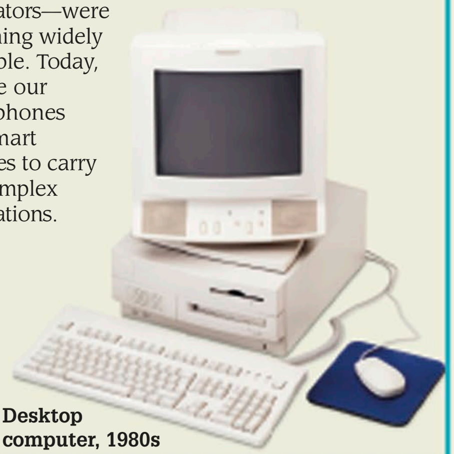
Comptometers were first made in the 1880s and were a main feature of office life until late into the 1970s, with the arrival of the electronic calculator. Primarily used for adding, the comptometer could also subtract, multiply, and divide. Trained operators pressed more than one key at a time to carry out rapid calculations.



Comptometer, c 1920

Calculators for all

The development of pocket electronic calculators in the 1970s ended the need for mechanical devices such as slide rules and made it possible for everyone to do calculations at the press of a button. By the 1980s, computers—with their integrated electronic calculators—were becoming widely available. Today, we use our smartphones and smart watches to carry out complex calculations.



Desktop computer, 1980s

1822

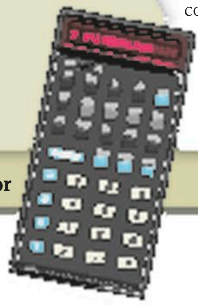
English mathematician Charles Babbage began work on the design of his first Difference Engine, a machine capable of performing complex calculations.

1940s

The first electronic programmable calculating machines were developed during World War II to aid in deciphering encoded enemy messages.

1970s

Pocket-sized electronic calculators began to replace other kinds of calculating machines at work, school, and in the home.



Pocket electronic calculator

1980s

Small, powerful desktop computers with inbuilt electronic calculators became widely available.